9. Riding the Waves: The Emergence of China as a Maritime Power

During the Tang dynasty, China had a remarkably cosmopolitan society, with an openness to foreign cultures and lands, including India (as we saw in Chapters 4 and 6). But by the first decade of the tenth century, the Tang dynasty was in decline, and China once again fell into an extended period of turmoil and fragmentation. There were several contending polities, both large and small, which succeeded the Tang. In the Chinese annals, this period between 907 CE and 960 CE came to be known as the Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms era. This unsettled phase of perpetual and violent conflict eventually led to the country falling under the sway of three major empires, two of them non-Han polities and one Han.

Central and southern China came under the rule of the Song dynasty (960–1279 CE) who were indigenous Han. The western part of China, including the oasis towns of Central Asia, which constitutes much of present-day China's Xinjiang province, came under the rule of the Tangut tribes from the steppes. They ruled as the Western Xia or Xi Xia dynasty from 1038 CE to 1227 CE .

Northern China came to be ruled by the ethnic tribes from the Manchurian region and Mongolia, known as Khitan (from which China came to be known as Cathay). The Khitan Liao dynasty held sway from 907 CE to 1125 CE , and the Song emperor had to send it tribute. The Khitans, in turn, lost their empire to the Jurchen tribes from Manchuria in 1125 CE . The latter then ruled the former Liao empire as the Jin dynasty from 1115 CE to 1234 CE .

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The Song dynasty, which would play a major role in China's growth as a maritime power, ruled from Kaifeng (in the present-day province of Henan)